

RICH AND POOR

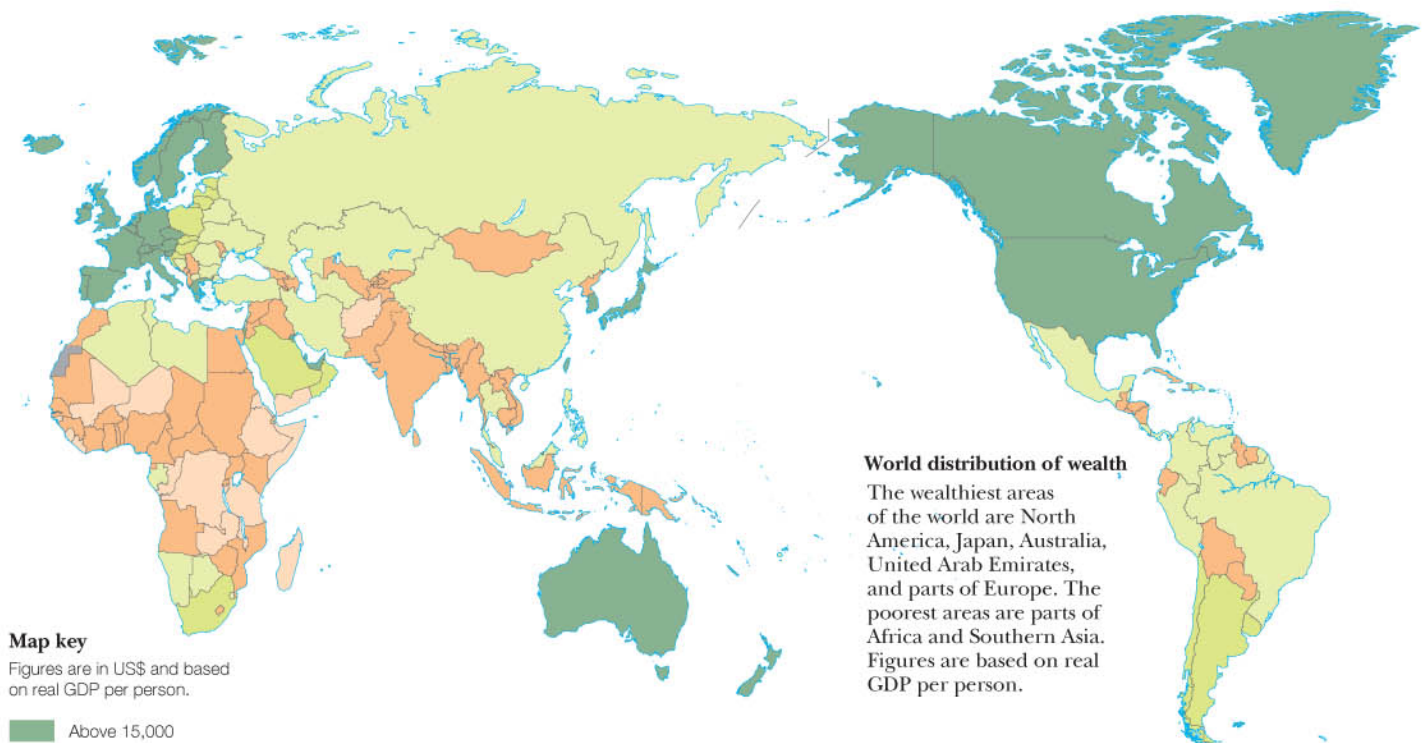
THE DIFFERENCE IN WEALTH between the richest and poorest countries is vast. The average person in Mozambique earns one six-hundredth of the average person's wages in Switzerland. How wealthy a country is depends on its natural resources, industrial strength, population size, and political stability. Libya is much richer than its neighbor, Chad. Both are desert countries with small populations, but Libya has oil while Chad has few natural resources. Many poor countries borrow money from richer countries. Debt repayment is difficult, with the result that poor countries stay poor, while rich countries continue to grow richer.

POOREST COUNTRIES (Based on real GDP per person)	
Country	US\$
East Timor	400
Malawi	600
Sierra Leone	600
Somalia	600
Burundi	600

RICHEST COUNTRIES (Based on real GDP per person)	
Country	US\$
Luxembourg	58,900
U.S.	40,100
Norway	40,000
San Marino	34,600
Switzerland	33,800

NATIONAL WEALTH

There are two official measures of national wealth. The Gross Domestic Product (GDP) measures the total value of finished goods and services produced by a national economy. The Gross National Product (GNP) measures GDP and the income from abroad that flows into the country. Both figures are usually expressed in U.S. dollars. When the figures are divided by the total population of the country, they give an indication of how rich or poor that country is. The tables on the left show that the five richest countries are in Europe and the U.S., while the five poorest countries are in Africa and Asia.



Map key

Figures are in US\$ and based on real GDP per person.

- Above 15,000
- 10,000–15,000
- 5,000–10,000
- 1,000–5,000
- Below 1,000
- Figures not available

ABSOLUTE AND RELATIVE POVERTY

About a quarter of the world's population lives in "absolute poverty." This means that their basic needs for a healthy life are not met: they have little or no food to eat, no access to safe drinking water, and are often homeless. The vast majority of these people live in southern and eastern Asia and the area south of the Sahara in Africa. Many more people live in "relative poverty," which means they are much poorer than the majority of people living in the same country.

World distribution of wealth

The wealthiest areas of the world are North America, Japan, Australia, United Arab Emirates, and parts of Europe. The poorest areas are parts of Africa and Southern Asia. Figures are based on real GDP per person.

Women washing clothes at a watering hole in Burkina Faso

